

ZOKARIO EDITIONS

Letters to a Young Painter

*Letters on craft, doubt and beauty for an
artist at the beginning of the road*

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On Beginning Badly

You ask, in a letter I have now read three times, whether you have talent, and you ask it the way a patient asks for a diagnosis, bracing for the worst. I will disappoint you at once: I cannot see talent, and neither can anyone else who is honest. At the beginning it does not exist in a visible form. What I can see in your pages is appetite, which is rarer than talent and far more useful, because appetite gets up in the morning. Talent is a rumor other people start about you years later, once the work is done. Do not wait for the rumor.

So begin, and begin badly, because there is no other door. Every painter you admire kept a drawer they showed no one, full of horses like dogs and hands like gloves left out in the rain. The drawer is not the shameful part of the story; it is the story. Those thousand poor drawings are the tuition, paid in the only currency the craft accepts. When your hand betrays you tonight, and it will, do not read it as a verdict. Read it as a receipt. You have paid another day toward an eye and a hand that will one day agree with each other.

As for what to draw, do not go looking for beauty yet; beauty is shy around beginners and it can smell ambition. Draw what is in front of you and beneath your notice. The kitchen chair. Your own left hand, that patient model who works without pay. The coat on the hook,

hanging with more sorrow than most martyrdoms manage in oil. If you can be faithful to the chair, faithful to how its shadow pools on the floor and nowhere else in the world, you will have learned the whole trade in miniature. Everything I know about painting saints I learned from furniture.

I will not promise you success, since I have no idea what the word will mean by the time you deserve it. I promise you something better and stranger: the work will change you faster than you change the work. In a year you will see shadows where you now see nothing, and colors inside colors, like rooms opening off a corridor, and you will walk through the ordinary world as if it had been repainted overnight by someone who loved it. That is the wage, and it is paid daily. Write to me again when the paper wins, and it will win often. I will be here.



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